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Videoconferencing With IMs

Find out what the person on the other side of an IM looks like

Today, all of us have our favourite Instant Messenger (IM), and chances are, it's either MSN Messenger or Yahoo! Messenger. Communication is a snap, and we rarely even think about it anymore—when you want to chat with someone, you just log on and if they're not online, send them an SMS, telling them to get online, "NOW!". All this is not necessarily across continents; we at *Digit* do it across office bays!

Videoconferencing, hitherto a dream hampered by abysmal bandwidth—a result of the fact that the majority of Internet users in India connect through dial-up—has gained popularity thanks to the growing reach of 'Broadband' (we prefer to call it always-on, for obvious reasons), and people are now videoconferencing, using their favourite IM. So let's see how you can go about setting this up.

STEP 1 The Basics

A Web cam streams images on the Web by taking still images after small intervals of time. A standard TV displays images at 25 frames per second (fps); a Web cam takes images at about 15 fps.

In order to get a clear image, keep the light source behind the Web cam. You also need to remember that the video clarity is directly proportional to your connection speed, so if you use dial-up, expect to get very noticeable lag between images.

STEP 2 What You Need

A PC, webcam, microphone, Internet connection, Yahoo! or Hotmail/MSN account and an installed copy of MSN or Yahoo! Messenger—the accounts and IMs can be created and downloaded for free. Remember, these criteria apply to the person you are videoconferencing with as well. You can view another person's webcam without having one yourself, but that wouldn't be videoconferencing, would it!

STEP 3 Setting Up

Setting up your PC is simple: just plug your webcam,

microphone and speakers or headphones into the proper sockets and install the software. Both, MSN and Yahoo! Messenger, will detect the webcam automatically.

STEP 4 Conferencing

You need to configure the sound and the video in your Web cam and microphone before you can use videoconferencing.

MSN Messenger

As with all things, MSN provides a wizard for this.

In the MSN messenger window, go to Tools > Audio/Video Tuning Wizard.



MSN Audio/Video tuning wizard

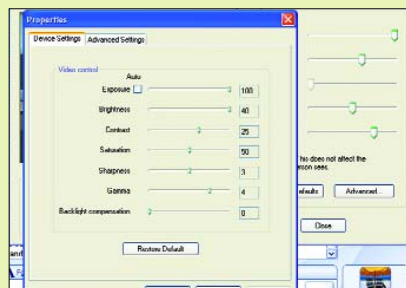
Just follow the on-screen instructions from then on—it will test your speakers for sound and your microphone for clarity. Now just go to Actions > Start a videoconference... and choose the contact you want to start the conference with or just right-click a contact and choose "Start a videoconference".

Once you start your conference, you may want to improve on the image quality of your webcam. Just go to 'Tools > Web camera settings'. Here you can adjust the brightness, contrast and other image options.

Click on 'Advanced' for more detailed tweaking. Repositioning the pop-up window will also show you the changes as they take place.

Yahoo! Messenger

To set up your webcam, microphone



Adjusting the Web cam image

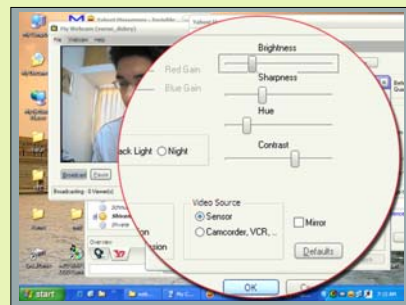
and speakers in Yahoo! Messenger, go to 'Help > Audio Setup Wizard'. Just follow the simple on-screen instructions.

Yahoo! also tests for the echo level of the room you are in, and makes automatic adjustments.

Now, go to 'Messenger > Start My Webcam'. This will start your webcam



Yahoo! audio tuning



Yahoo video tuning

and ask you to configure a few basic options. One great feature here is 'Super Webcam', which will let you send clearer, sharper and higher frame rate video. Of course, both you and the person you are conferencing with need to have fast connections.

The one irritating aspect about Yahoo! Messenger is that there is no single option for starting a videoconference—you will need to start video- and audio conference separately.